



Figure 1: Setting a password to decrypt the home directory



Figure 2: Pidgin chat window with OTR enabled

often provide very slow connections, especially the free ones.

To overcome this problem, a Firefox plug-in called FoxyProxy is available. Essentially, FoxyProxy enables us to route certain sites through the proxy server, whereas the other sites will be loaded without using the proxy server. Hence,

the negative effect on our browsing is minimal. We can set up which proxy server is to be used for which sites, and governed by which rules, white lists, etc.

FoxyProxy is also used to access websites that are region-locked, for example, [www.hulu.com](http://www.hulu.com). One must remember that the level of anonymity gained in this process is essentially dependent on the proxy server that is used. While some proxy servers (mostly paid for) do offer complete anonymity, they are never really 100 per cent reliable. In fact, one of the most secure ways to surf is to use FoxyProxy along with the Tor network. The best method to set this up is explained on the FoxyProxy FAQ at <http://foxyproxy.mozdev.org/faq.html>.

Another aspect of browsing security involves surfing while leaving virtually no trace of the browsing activity on the client PC. The latest version of Firefox and Chrome both provide a 'Private Browsing' mode, using which no Web history, form history, or cookies are saved on the client machines—essentially, it tries to avoid leaving any traces of your Internet activity on the client machines. Available under the **Tools** menu in Firefox, this mode is very useful when you use the Internet for online banking and other e-commerce activities. One must remember that while surfing in this mode, it is possible that your ISP or any hacker can monitor the connection.

## Computer auto-locking

This is definitely one of the coolest ways to increase the security of your system. Usually, in large offices, employees lock their computers whenever they have to step out of their seats. Doing this again and again surely gets frustrating. But now, using software called BlueProximity, you can set your computer to automatically lock/unlock depending on your distance from the computer. You can do this if your computer is Bluetooth-enabled and you have a cell phone with Bluetooth capabilities.

Once BlueProximity is set up, it will automatically detect the approximate distance between the cell phone and the computer, and lock the screen once you move away. And when you come back near the computer, it gets unlocked. This software is really a boon for people who are tired of typing their passwords again and again. BlueProximity can also be set up to run any other shell command that you want. Hence, you can make it turn off the monitor, change the song that is playing or do just about anything that you can imagine.

## Keepass password safe

Anyone who knows a thing or two about security will agree that having the same password for multiple sites and applications is a *huge* security hazard. One of the main reasons why we use the same password everywhere is because it's too difficult to remember different passwords, while keeping them cryptic enough. So to overcome these problems, the best way is to use a password manager.

One of the best ones that I recommend is KeePass, a cross-platform, open source password manager. You can use it to store all the passwords in its database. Then you have to remember just the master password for KeePass and you can access all the other information.

The developers of KeePass have taken a lot of trouble to make it as secure as possible, employing various advanced algorithms. It is completely portable and can be used from a USB disk also. It even has features that can prevent a key logger from deciphering the passwords.

This just about sums up how to secure most of your common Internet-linked activities in a user-friendly manner. Anyone trying out these tips must remember that 100 per cent security is possible only in theory. There is no method that can give you complete security. But for most practical purposes, the methods suggested in this article should be good enough. If you too have any similar tips, do share them with us. **END** 

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